

3ds max 8

Design To The Max

Loyalists would beat our doors down for saying this, but 3ds max is not perfect. Release 8, for the most part, is for those loyalists. As usual, we find Autodesk's three-point approach here as well:

1. Fix annoying bugs
2. Pick a good plugin; buy rights and hire the developers to make it better
3. Keep everything looking the same so users feel at home

Add to all this a nifty alternative to the old and tedious UVW texture mapping, and you've got a 20-second review of 3ds max 8.

Ripping Out Skins

To ease the lives of texture artists, Autodesk has introduced the unique Pelt-mapping feature. In a few short clicks, you can tear your model apart, turning it into a spread-out version of itself, something like the bear-rugs you see sprawled out on people's floors. This makes it much easier to apply textures, especially to complex models like humans and animals. Even better, you can now render the spread-out version of your model and bring it into Photoshop to help you plan your texture.

Putting Hair On Your Chest

The most exciting development in 3dsmax is that Autodesk has *finally* absorbed a good plugin to add hair or fur to characters. In the true spirit of late but fashionable entries, this one doesn't disappoint—the new Hair Modifier is *really* easy to use, and hair can be fully animated. It also has support for collisions and other dynamics, giving it a more realistic feel. The setup screen for the plugin doesn't contain buttons for navigating the view, unfortunately, so you will need to educate yourself with some keyboard shortcuts ([Alt] + middle-click for rotating your view, etc.). Another gripe we have about the plugin is that it's quite eccentric—it would crash every so often, though we did get lucky sometimes. Service pack 1 contains a fix for this, so fret not.

Covering That Chest

Thus far, cloth animation has been left to third party plugins—even though the cloth functions used to come with Reactor, bundled with 3ds max. We've often found the Reactor cloth modifier a little daunting, and have been dying for something friendlier—like the SimCloth plugin. Now, in addition to Reactor's cloth, you also get a Cloth modifier which is *much* easier to use. This, like most cloth plugins, comes with its own kinks—we tried to do a scene with a towel hanging on a horizontal pole, only to find that the cloth goes clean through the pole! Still, a few tweaks and an unavoidable increase in polygon counts can help counter the effects.

Even making your cloth meshes is a lot easier this time. Rather



than painstakingly build the entire mesh, you can just build the individual pieces and "sew" them together tailor-style with the Garment Maker—quick and painless.

Going Mental

3ds max 8 *bundles* the Mental Ray renderer with it. This should have fans whooping with joy, for at one time, Mental Ray would cost the same as 3ds max, if not more. The license has been opened up a tad, too, so you need not buy separate Mental Ray licenses to render your scenes over networks. The renderer itself is expectedly powerful—the simulation of real-life lighting is eerily accurate, but the documentation expects you to be a physicist, making it an extremely difficult thing to learn. The best idea is to feel around and stop when you find a setting you like.

What Do You Want From Me?

Overall, 3ds max 8 mainly addresses user brickbats more than anything else. There is little surprise here—we wanted all this, and we got it. While we still maintain that it's gob-smackingly awesome for 3D modelling, the special effects department demands some more attention. Fire effects, for example, are still restricted to the staid atmosphere gizmos—we want something like the Particle/Object Combustion plugins that have been around since Release 2.5 and make playing with fire so much fun.

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